FFFA Donor Management: Setup Guide

28 October 2026 · Empact × FFFA AI Impact Sprint

This guide is for whoever looks after the system for FFFA: a staff member working with an AI coding assistant, a volunteer developer or a freelancer. It covers configuration, access, approved fields, workflow rules and troubleshooting. The **Prompt Guide** has ready-to-paste instructions for an AI assistant to do each technical step.

What FFFA receives

Item	Where
The code and its history	GitHub repository `FFFA-Donor-Management-System`
How to run it	`README.md`
This guide	`docs/SETUP_GUIDE.md` (and `.pdf`)
How staff use it day to day	`docs/staff-guide/STAFF_GUIDE.md` (and `.pdf`)
How to set up and change it with an AI assistant	`docs/PROMPT_GUIDE.md` (and `.pdf`)
Technical design (database, rules, AI safeguards)	`docs/SYSTEM_DESIGN_v1.3.md` and `docs/SYSTEM_DESIGN.pdf`
Read before using real data	`docs/FFFA_DISCLAIMERS.md`
20-minute demo script	`docs/DEMO_SCRIPT.md`

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1. Access: take ownership on GitHub

FFFA should own the code, so access never depends on a former volunteer.

1. **Create a GitHub account** for FFFA at github.com, with a shared FFFA email (e.g. tech@ or admin@), not a personal one.
2. **Create a free organisation:** profile picture → *Your organizations* → *New organization* → *Free*, e.g. `free-food-for-all`.
3. **Move the repository:** the current owner opens the repository → *Settings* → *General* → *Danger Zone* → *Transfer ownership* → the FFFA organisation. FFFA accepts the transfer. The code, history and documents now belong to FFFA.
4. **Give people access:** *Settings* → *Collaborators and teams* → *Add people*. Use *Write* for people who make changes. Keep *Admin* for FFFA. Remove access when someone leaves.
5. **Protect the live version (recommended):** *Settings* → *Branches* → add a rule for `main` requiring a pull request before merging, so every change is reviewed before it reaches staff.
6. **Keep every service account in FFFA's name:** GitHub, Supabase (database and login), Google (AI key) and the hosting provider. Use the shared FFFA email and store passwords in FFFA's password manager.

Staff access inside the app. There are two roles. **Staff** use Follow-ups, Donors, Dashboard and Import. **Admins** can also change Settings, export donors to Excel and permanently delete a donor for PDPA requests. Staff accounts are added in the database's `staff` table (email, name, role). There is no screen for this yet.

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2. Set up a computer

Any Mac or Windows computer. All of these are free.

Install	From	Check
Git	git-scm.com (Mac: may already be installed)	`git --version`
Node.js 20 or newer (LTS)	nodejs.org	`node --version`
GitHub Desktop, the easiest way to sign in to GitHub and download the code	desktop.github.com	Sign in with the FFFA GitHub account
An AI coding assistant that can read files and run commands, e.g. Claude Code, GitHub Copilot in VS Code, or Cursor	The provider's website	Open it on the project folder

Get the code: GitHub Desktop → *File* → *Clone repository* → `FFFA-Donor-Management-System`. Or use the first prompt in the Prompt Guide.

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3. Run it on a computer

In a Terminal opened in the project folder:

```
npm install --legacy-peer-deps
npm run demo
```

Open **http://localhost:3000**. You're signed in automatically as a practice admin. Press **Ctrl + C** to stop.

Command	What it does
`npm run demo`	Starts with 9 built-in practice donors
`npm run dev`	Starts with an empty database (use this to try the Excel import)
`npm run demo:files`	Creates two practice Excel files in `docs/samples/` (`fffa-demo-donors.xlsx`, `fffa-demo-update.xlsx`). Re-run on the day you use them, because their dates are relative to today.
`npm run demo:reset`	Wipes the local practice database (`.data/`)
`npm test`	Runs the automatic checks. All must pass before a change goes live.
`npm run lint`	Checks the code for type errors

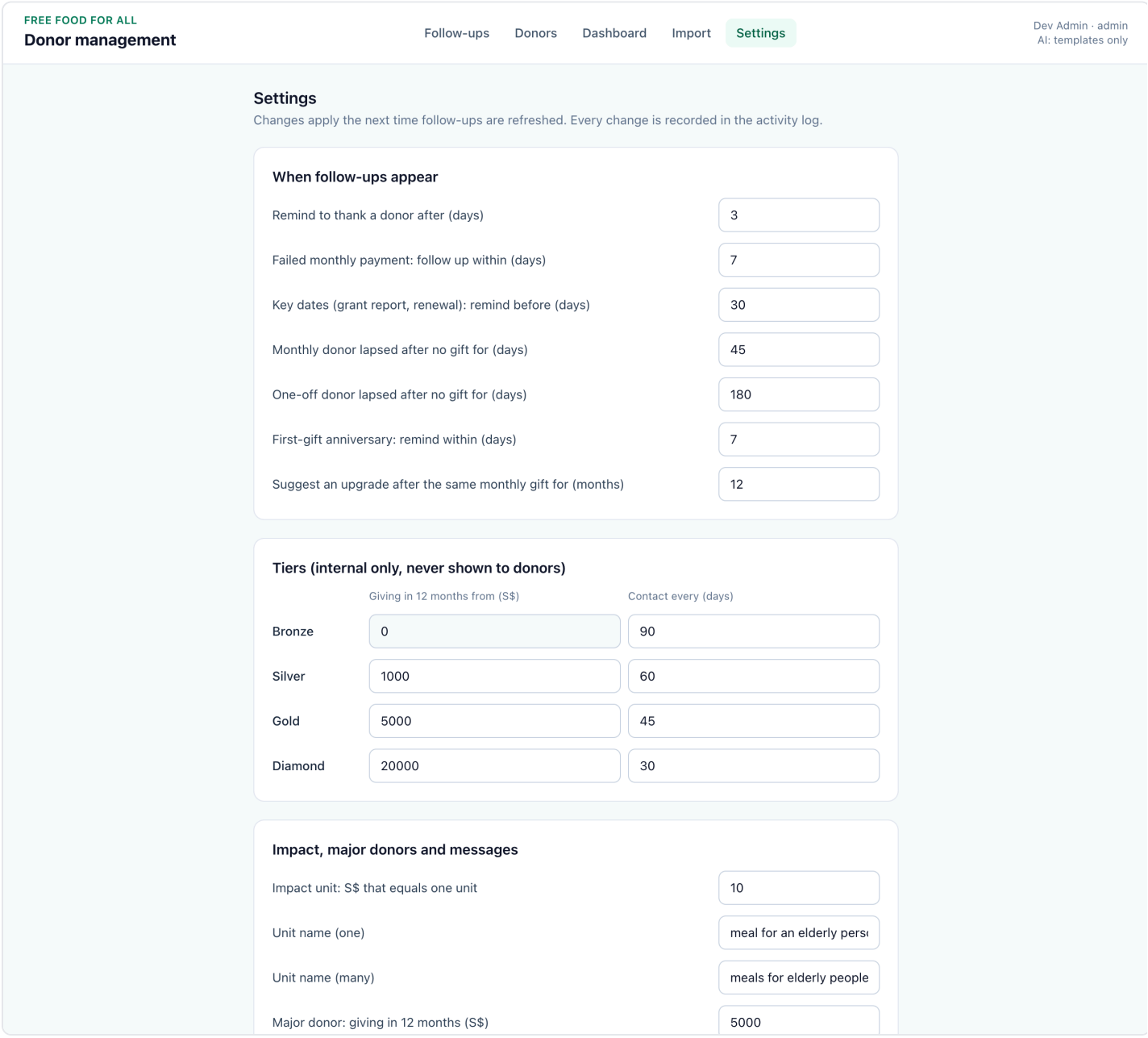
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4. Configuration

Server settings go in a `.env` file on a computer (copy `.env.example`) or in the hosting dashboard. They hold secrets, so they are never written into code or shared in chat.

Setting	Purpose
`DATABASE_URL`	Where data is stored (Supabase Postgres). Empty = a local practice database in `.data/`.
`AUTH_MODE`	`dev` = automatic practice login (computer only). `supabase` = real staff login (required online; `dev` is refused there).
`GEMINI_API_KEY`	Turns on AI drafting. Empty = standard templates (the header shows "AI: templates only").
`GEMINI_MODEL`	Gemini model (default `gemini-3.6-flash`).
`PORT`	Web port (default 3000).

FFFA settings are changed by an admin on the **Settings** screen. Changes apply the next time follow-ups are refreshed, and every change is recorded in the activity log with the old and new value. The values are listed in section 6.



5. Approved fields

These are the only things the system stores. The Excel import template uses the same fields.

Record	Fields	Notes
Donor	Type (individual, corporate, grant funder); organisation name; first and last name (the contact person, for organisations) and their title; preferred name; email; mobile; how they know FFFA; programme interest (e.g. RTE, KidsLuvIt, Food Redistribution); also volunteers; major-donor tag; relationship owner	Email and mobile are never sent to the AI
Donation	Date; cash amount (S$), or for goods a description and estimated value; channel (Giving.sg, GIVE.asia, bank, PayNow, in person, other); platform reference; campaign; programme; monthly or one-off (and monthly amount); payment status (succeeded or failed); thanked	Never deleted. Mistakes are voided with a reason.
Key date	Type (sponsorship expiry, grant report, grant renewal, other); due date; label; completed	
Note	Short relationship note, author, date	No sensitive personal data
Conversation	Date, channel, summary and the exact message sent	Saved when a message is marked as sent
Follow-up	Reason, due date, status	Created by the rules, never typed in
AI draft	Generated text, approved text, who approved, when sent	Kept so quality can be checked

Never store NRIC, FIN, passport or UEN numbers; bank or card details; age, income, ethnicity, health or other sensitive details. Tax-deductible receipts (IRAS) are not supported. Adding ID numbers later needs a separate, encrypted, admin-only design (system design, section 3).

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6. Workflow rules

The follow-up queue is filled by these rules. All numbers can be changed on the Settings screen.

Follow-up	Appears when	Default
Thank-you due	A gift (cash or goods) is not marked thanked after N days	3 days
Failed payment	A monthly payment failed within the last N days	7 days
Key date	A key date is due within N days	30 days
Going cold	No logged contact for longer than the donor's tier allows	see tiers
Lapsed	No gift for N days	45 days (monthly donors), 180 days (one-off)
Anniversary	First-gift anniversary within N days	7 days
Upgrade ask	Same monthly amount for N months, not asked in the last year	12 months

Tier (internal, never shown to donors)	Cash giving in 12 months from	Contact at least every
Bronze	S$0	90 days
Silver	S$1,000	60 days
Gold	S$5,000	45 days
Diamond	S$20,000	30 days

- **Major donors** get personal outreach and no AI drafts: S$5,000+ in 12 months, 3+ years with FFFA, or tagged as major (Excel column `major_override`).
- **Impact figure:** S$10 = 1 meal for an elderly person. **Message sign-off:** *"Warm regards, The Free Food For All team"*. Both can be changed in Settings.
- **When rules run:** whenever someone presses the refresh icon on Follow-ups, and after a Giving.sg / GIVE.asia platform import. A follow-up is never created twice, and one that was closed stays closed.
- **Importing history:** mark old gifts `thanked = Yes` in the Excel file. Otherwise every past gift older than 3 days becomes a thank-you follow-up.
- **New imports start "going cold"** because no contact history exists yet. This settles once staff log messages.

AI drafting rules (the instructions are in `server/services/ai/prompts.ts` and the templates in `server/services/ai/fallback.ts`):

- The AI sees only the donor's name, giving history, interests, key date, the latest 3 notes (with emails, phone numbers and NRICs removed) and impact figures worked out by the system. It never sees email, mobile, tier or ID numbers.
- It may only use facts given to it, with no pressure or guilt, at most one ask, 80–150 words, and FFFA's sign-off.
- If the AI fails or has no key, standard templates are used.
- The system never sends anything. Staff approve and send every message themselves.
- After changing the wording, bump `PROMPT_VERSION` in `prompts.ts` so old and new drafts can be told apart.

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7. What is built, and what is not

Built and tested (85 automatic tests):

- **Follow-ups:** rule-based queue, refresh, AI or template draft → edit → approve → copy / open in email → mark as sent (saved to conversation history), with major donors blocked from AI
- **Donors:** search, filter by type, add donor, profile with giving, tier and years with FFFA, log cash or in-kind donations (one-off or monthly), add notes, see key dates, export to Excel (admin)
- **Dashboard:** totals only
- **Import:** Excel template with preview, matching, duplicate protection and decisions on unsure rows
- **Settings:** all rules, tiers, impact figure, major-donor thresholds and sign-off (admin)
- **Behind the scenes, with no screen yet:**
  - Giving.sg / GIVE.asia CSV import (`/api/import/preview` , `/commit`)
  - follow-up done, snooze and dismiss
  - edit and archive donors
  - void donations
  - add and complete key dates
  - delete notes
  - permanent delete (admin)
  - activity log (`/api/activity`)

Not built yet. The README status table is the up-to-date list.

Item	Needed before real donor data?
Staff login (Supabase Auth). Without it the app refuses to start online.	**Yes**
Daily automatic rules run (today someone presses refresh)	Recommended
"Today" in Singapore time (dates use UTC, so before 8am "today" can be a day behind)	Recommended
Screens for the behind-the-scenes actions above, a staff accounts screen, and an activity log screen	As needed

The Prompt Guide has a ready prompt for each.

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8. Put it online

Do this once, with the AI assistant (Prompt Guide, section 3). Keys go in the hosting settings, never in code or chat.

1. **Database and login: Supabase** (supabase.com, free tier to start, **Singapore region**). Copy the connection string (*Project Settings* → *Database*) into `DATABASE_URL`. Tables are created automatically on first start. Turn on daily backups.
2. **Build the login** (see section 7), then add each staff member to the `staff` table with their role.
3. **AI key: Google Gemini** (aistudio.google.com). Create a key and **turn on billing**: on the paid tier, Google does not use FFFA's data to improve its products. Put it in `GEMINI_API_KEY`. Check this against FFFA's PDPA consent first (`docs/FFFA_DISCLAIMERS.md`).
4. **Hosting: e.g. Render** (render.com → *New Web Service* → the FFFA repository). Google Cloud Run or Railway work the same way.

Setting	Value
Build command	`npm install --legacy-peer-deps && npm run build`
Start command	`npm start`
Environment	`DATABASE_URL`, `AUTH_MODE=supabase`, `GEMINI_API_KEY`, plus the Supabase keys the login needs

   Every merge to `main` then updates the live site.
5. **Before entering real donors:**
   - ☐ Login works, and someone not in the staff table cannot get in
   - ☐ `DATABASE_URL` points to Supabase. Without it, data is lost on every restart.
   - ☐ Backups are on, and one restore has been tested
   - ☐ No practice data in the live database (never run `npm run demo` or `demo:files` imports against it)
   - ☐ One test donor goes through the whole flow, from import to mark as sent
   - ☐ PDPA items in `docs/FFFA_DISCLAIMERS.md` are signed off

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9. Data protection (PDPA)

- Donor data lives only in FFFA's database. The AI receives no contact details or ID numbers.
- Admins can permanently delete a donor on request. Donors are otherwise archived, and donations voided, never deleted.

- Every import, edit, draft, approval, send, settings change and export is recorded in the activity log (who, what, when), without personal details.
- Excel exports contain personal data. Store them securely and delete old copies.
- `.env` is never uploaded to GitHub (`.gitignore` blocks it). Keep it that way.

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10. Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
`npm install` fails ("ERESOLVE", "edgesOut")	`npm install --legacy-peer-deps`
Tests fail right after pulling new code	Run `npm install --legacy-peer-deps` again, because new packages may have been added
"Port 3000 is already in use"	Another copy is running. Close it, or `PORT=3001 npm run dev`
Practice data looks wrong or duplicated	Ctrl + C, `npm run demo:reset` , start again
Follow-ups list is empty after an import	Press the refresh icon at the top of the list
Hundreds of "Thank-you due" after importing history	Old gifts were imported as not thanked. Set `thanked = Yes` in the file. For an import already done, ask the AI assistant to mark gifts before a chosen date as thanked.
Excel import says a sheet or column is missing	Download a fresh template from the Import screen. Keep the sheet names and row 1 headers.
Drafts always say "Template"	`GEMINI_API_KEY` is missing, or billing is off
App won't start online: "AUTH_MODE=dev is not allowed"	Set `AUTH_MODE=supabase` . The login must be built first (section 7).
Live site errors	Hosting dashboard → *Logs*. Paste the error into the AI assistant, after removing keys and donor details.

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11. Bringing in a developer

Add them on GitHub with *Write* access, and share this guide, the Prompt Guide, `README.md` and the system design. Ask for every change as a pull request that FFFA approves, and remove their access when the work is done. All accounts stay in FFFA's name.